had been prepared to give assurances that there would be no invasion of Cuba. However, the Soviet shipments of arms to the island, beginning in July, had changed the situation. Kennedy called it “the most dangerous situation since the end of the war.” Gromyko wrote in his memoirs that Kennedy kept talking about the “offensive weapons,” and never asked him about the missiles. “Mr. President,” he was supposed to tell Kennedy if confronted with the missile question, “the Soviet Union delivered to Cuba a limited number of missiles of the defensive character. They will never threaten anybody.” But Kennedy never asked the feared question. “There was no need for me to say whether there were any or not,” recalled Gromyko.[9]

Gromyko noticed the change in Kennedy’s tone, finding him nervous and Rusk unusually tense, but failed to attribute the rising tension to the discovery of the missiles. Anatoly Dobrynin, the Soviet ambassador in Washington, remembered later that Gromyko was pleased with its outcome. “He was completely misled by Kennedy’s conduct,” wrote the ambassador in his memoirs. When he filed his report about the meeting with Kennedy, Gromyko wrote that public support for the invasion of Cuba was fading, while the media were paying more and more attention to Berlin. He did not see any signs of an imminent invasion. “Everything we know about the U.S. position on Cuba,” wrote Gromyko, “permits the conclusion that the situation is in general wholly satisfactory.”[10]

The meeting with Gromyko, which began at 5:00 p.m., ended after 7:15. Throughout the day, Kennedy heard reports from his Cuban advisory team on the meetings that they had conducted in smaller groups. At 9:15 p.m. he called them all into the White House to assess the situation. While Kennedy himself continued to favor a surgical strike, the momentum for that solution, which had developed in response to news about the Soviet IRBM launch sites in Cuba, had been lost. “During the course of the day, opinions had obviously switched from the advantages of a first strike on the missile sites and on Cuban aviation to a blockade,” dictated Kennedy into a microphone when the meeting was over. After recounting the positions taken by his advisers, he remarked: “The consensus was that we should go ahead with the blockade beginning on Sunday night.”[11]